

Develop Your Positioning Message

Your positioning message presents you with an opportunity to positively position yourself in the minds of listeners. What should be included? How should it be conveyed?

Components of your positioning message will be woven into your networking conversations, meetings, cover letters, and interviews. Thus your message is not a memorized statement about yourself, but rather a group of points that you can use to support your candidacy.

Exercise One

Develop the components of your message by answering the bulleted questions below. Consider what will be most important and relevant to your audience as you construct the points.

Remember, what you choose to highlight might change based on the target audience and the situation. It's best to come up with as many points as possible and selectively choose how to weave them into your communication.

- Who are you?

- What's your career focus? Why?

- What about your prior experience suggest reasons for targeting this career?

- What environments do you thrive in and how do those match this career?

- In what ways do you excel as a(n):
Individual Contributor?

Team player?

Leader?

- What stories about your experiences support your claims above?

- In addition to your coursework, in what other ways have you prepared yourself for this career transition?

- What other things would you like to convey about yourself?

Convey Your Positioning Message to Others

Exercise Two

The best way to evaluate your positioning message is through practice. Role-play a networking conversation with a friend. Can you weave some the points above into your conversation without sounding forced or rehearsed? Evaluate your delivery style and content.

Delivery Style:

- Did you speak clearly? With enthusiasm? With confidence?
- Was the pace of your speech appropriate? (i.e., did you speak too fast? Did it sound rehearsed?)

Content:

- Was the information conveyed easy to follow?
- Were there any elements that seemed to be missing?
- Were there any particular parts of the conversation that you struggled with?
- Did you engage your audience?